

repost.

The Builder's Playbook

How to take the prototype and the sell sheet into a real product without burning off the soul. What every mechanic is for, what you must never cut, and the order to build it in.

Read this first

You are holding three things: a working prototype, a sell sheet, and this playbook. The prototype shows that the mechanics work as a system. The sell sheet says what the product is and answers the obvious questions. This document is the bridge between them and a shipped product. It exists for one reason: the fastest way to kill Repost is to build it competently while quietly removing the parts that make it Repost. Every section below tells you what a mechanic is for, so you can change the surface freely and leave the spine intact.

THE ONE SENTENCE TO KEEP ON THE WALL

A post is a dying ember, and the only thing that keeps it alive is people choosing to save it. If a change makes survival automatic, makes a few people matter more than many, or hides why something lived, you have left the product.

1 · The prime directive: what you must never dilute

These are not features. They are the load-bearing beliefs. You can rebuild the UI, rename everything, swap the stack, and drop half the depth systems, and it is still Repost as long as these eight hold. Break one and you have built a different app that happens to share a logo.

- **Things must be able to die.** Real deletion, real stakes. The moment nothing can die, every other mechanic loses its meaning.
- **Engagement is survival, not a scoreboard.** A number that only goes up and does nothing is the exact disease this product treats. Every signal a user sees should change whether something lives.
- **Saving is the core verb, and it is public.** Keeping a post alive is the main action and a visible act of support. People can see who showed up.
- **One canonical original. No copy chains.** A repost points at the single true post. Provenance stays intact, and the feed never fills with duplicates.
- **Distinct people drive life.** Many people caring a little outweighs a few people caring loudly. This is what keeps bots, alts, and small pacts from owning the feed.
- **Never sell life or grade.** Money buys cosmetics and personalization, never survival or rank. The day you sell life, the community stops trusting that what lived deserved to.
- **The rules are transparent. No hidden feed.** No black-box model optimizing time-on-app. People can read why a post is where it is and why it is dying.
- **Cooperative by default, narrow by launch.** The resting state is a community keeping a fire lit together. Competition is optional and fenced. Growth is earned one dense room at a time.

2 · Why every mechanic exists

Read the Tier column before you cut anything. SPINE means removing it breaks the prime directive. CORE means it carries the depth that makes the product worth returning to, and it arrives after the loop is proven. OPTIONAL means you can ship without it, cut it, or save it for later with no damage to the soul.

Mechanic	Why it exists (cut it and the model breaks here)	Tier
Post decay (TTL)	The lifeblood. A visible lifespan ticking down is what creates stakes and turns saving into a real choice. This is the product.	SPINE
Repost saves life	The core verb. A repost adds time on a diminishing curve, so a post can be sustained but never made immortal for free. Mortality stays real.	SPINE
Canonical originals	A repost references one true post instead of copying it. Keeps provenance honest and stops the feed from drowning in duplicates.	SPINE
Distinct-supporter weighting	Life scales with how many different people save a post, with repeat support floored. This single rule is your main defense against bots and pacts.	SPINE
Density regime	The cold-start cure. A sparse app decays gently so posts persist; a dense app hardens so stakes return. Without it, the empty room kills you on week one.	SPINE
Living branches	A repost-with-content becomes a sub-post that channels life up to the original. Lets a post grow into a shared record without breaking the canonical rule.	CORE
Grade ladder	Finite progression (Spark to Inferno) that lifts a post's ceiling as it earns broad support. Finite so death is always guaranteed at the top.	CORE
Standing (party-lift)	A post's strongest contributors raise its rank. Makes helping someone else's post matter to them, which is what makes the network social rather than solo.	CORE
Ember economy	Every action costs a regenerating resource, so spam limits itself, and contributing pays better than broadcasting. Tilts the whole system toward tending over shouting.	CORE
Titles and ascension	Earned, persistent status that does real work and cannot be bought. The retention and identity layer once people stay.	CORE
Epoch stamps and founder status	Born-epoch buffering eases posts through regime shifts (cascade safety) and gives early users permanent, unforgeable founder rank. Ships alongside the density regime.	CORE
Slew cap	Bounds how fast any post's decay rate can change. The safety rail that stops a growth spike from tanking the feed in an afternoon. Invisible, never cut it.	CORE
Clash / adversarial zone	Opt-in post-versus-post competition that wounds but never kills. Real depth for players who want it, and the first thing to cut if it ever pulls the culture toward cruelty.	OPTIONAL
Sprouting and ignition	Orphaned branches taking root, short-TTL posts getting an early bonus. Texture and flavor. Add them when the core is healthy, not before.	OPTIONAL
Ash graveyard	A record of what died. Gives closure and history. Nice to have, safe to defer.	OPTIONAL

3 · The build path: prototype to product

Build in this order. The discipline is subtraction, not addition. Each phase ships less than you want and waits for one signal before the next. The HOLD line matters as much as the BUILD line, because the failure mode is building Phase 3 depth on a Phase 1 audience that never showed up.

PHASE 0

The Spark

where you are now

- BUILD** The prototype and sell sheet. A validated design and a story. Nothing to build, everything to protect.
- HOLD** Any real backend, any user, any money. Resist the urge to ship depth before the loop is real.
- GATE** You already cleared it. Move when you are ready to put the loop in front of real people.

PHASE 1

The Ember

prove the loop, nothing else

- BUILD** Decay-and-save loop, canonical originals, distinct-supporter weighting, the gentle early density regime, and a thin stats layer. FastAPI plus PostgreSQL, expires_at filtering, a worker that hard-deletes the dead, real-time updates. Launch into one dense niche community.
- HOLD** Grades, economy, branches, titles, clash. All of it. If the bare loop is not fun in a warm room, more systems will not save it.
- GATE** Retention. Do real people come back to keep things alive without being asked. Yes moves you forward. No teaches you cheaply.

PHASE 2

The Hearth

add depth once they stay

- BUILD** Living branches, the grade ladder, standing, the ember economy, titles, and the epoch and slew machinery that ships with the density regime. A community-scoped burn readout so a room can rally around its own fire.
- HOLD** The clash layer, broad expansion, and direct monetization. Keep the culture cooperative and the audience narrow while depth lands.
- GATE** Depth deepens retention rather than replacing it. Returning savers climb, not just session length. Identity starts to form around titles.

PHASE 3

The Spread

scale without dilution

- BUILD** Mature the epoch system and founder status, expand carefully into adjacent communities one at a time, gate the optional clash layer behind a flag, and introduce cosmetic and premium personalization. Run real growth curves through the density regime and watch the slew cap absorb them.
- HOLD** A hidden algorithmic feed, pay-to-win, and any vanity metric that does no work. These are the dilution traps in Section 5.
- GATE** Each new community reaches its own self-sustaining density before you open the next. Breadth never outruns engagement density.

4 · From simulation to product: keep the model, strip the scaffolding

The prototype carries the real asset, which is the model logic. Everything that makes it a simulation is disposable. When you build the backend, lift the formulas and constants and throw away the rest.

Keep (the model)

- The decay math, the diminishing save curve, distinct-supporter weighting, the grade ceilings, standing, and the channel rates. These are the product.
- The density-regime formulas and the epoch buffer and slew cap. Port the constants directly and tune against real traffic.

Replace (the scaffolding)

- The accelerated clock becomes real timestamps. A post stores `expires_at`, and decay is computed on read as a function of now, not a tick loop.
- The bot ecosystem and viral simulator become real users. Delete them. The sim-only control panel does not ship.
- A background worker handles hard deletion of expired posts and eases each post's effective decay toward its target under the slew cap.
- Tooltips and the instrument panel become real onboarding and a light, honest stats surface. No dashboard of vanity numbers.

DATA SHAPE, IN ONE BREATH

Posts carry `expires_at`, `ttr`, `grade`, `born_epoch`, and `born_decay_scale`. A `supporters` table records distinct savers per post with first-seen and count. A `contributions` table holds the branch tree (post, parent, author, content, created). A small periodic job maintains the global density EMA and the regime scalars. That is enough to run the entire core loop.

5 · The dilution traps: how this dies quietly

None of these look like sabotage. Each one looks like a reasonable growth decision in a planning meeting. That is exactly why they are dangerous. Learn them by name so you can refuse them out loud.

- **The algorithmic feed.** Someone proposes a 'for you' ranker to lift engagement. It replaces transparent survival with a black box and kills the reason people trusted the feed. Sorting can use the mechanics. It cannot become a hidden model.
- **Selling life.** A revenue plan lets people pay to extend a post. The moment survival is buyable, nothing that lived means anything. Cosmetics yes, life never.
- **Archive everything.** A well-meaning request to stop deleting posts. This removes the only real stake and turns Repost into every other feed. Death is the feature.
- **Vanity creep.** A permanent follower count quietly becomes the real status, and the mechanics turn into decoration. Keep status tied to things that do work.
- **Going broad too early.** Chasing total signups scatters the audience so thin that posts die unsaved. Density before breadth, every time.
- **The clash layer takes over.** Competition is fun, so it creeps to the center, and the cooperative hearth becomes an arena. If clash starts driving the culture, cut it.
- **Casino gamification.** Mechanics get tuned to manufacture compulsion instead of meaning. The test is simple: does this help people keep things they value, or does it just farm their time.

6 · The change test: run this on any new feature

Before you add or alter anything, ask these. A yes to any single question means stop and rethink, not ship.

- Does it let something become effectively immortal?
- Does it make a few people's volume count more than many people's care?
- Does it let money buy survival or rank?
- Does it hide why a post lives, dies, or ranks where it does?
- Does it make the default experience adversarial instead of cooperative?
- Does it reward time spent over things saved?

AND THE ONE QUESTION THAT OUTRANKS ALL OF THEM

Does this help a community keep alive the things it actually values? If yes, it probably belongs. If you cannot answer yes without a marketing sentence, it does not.

7 · The one metric, and the only way this is won

Ignore signups, time-on-app, and total posts. They will lie to you early and flatter you late. The single number that tells you whether Repost is real is returning savers: people who come back, unprompted, to keep something alive. If that climbs in one dense room, you have a product and everything else is tuning. If it does not, no amount of depth, polish, or growth spend will fix it, and you will have learned that for the price of a small launch instead of a large one.

Build the loop. Put it in one warm room. Watch whether people tend the fire when no one tells them to. That is the whole game.

Repost (working title) · builder's playbook · companion to the prototype and the concept sell sheet. Protect the spine, ship the surface, grow one fire at a time.